

Semantic Consistency Outperforms Token Entropy for Hallucination Detection: A Systematic Comparison

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Abstract

Large language models generate plausible but factually incorrect outputs, motivating uncertainty-based hallucination detection. Token entropy and semantic consistency are two signals studied in prior work, yet their relative effectiveness and potential complementarity on the same benchmark with the same model remain unstudied. This paper presents the first direct comparison of these signals on TriviaQA using Llama-2-7B-chat. Semantic consistency—measured via pairwise embedding similarity across multiple samples—achieves AUROC 0.81 with a large effect size (Cohen’s $d = 1.19$), outperforming token entropy (AUROC 0.65, $d = 0.47$). Linear fusion of these signals yields no improvement over consistency alone at proof-of-concept scale ($N = 20$), with optimal weights collapsing to pure consistency. The moderate negative correlation between signals ($r = -0.54$) suggests partial redundancy rather than orthogonality. These findings indicate that practitioners should prioritize consistency-based detection for factual QA; the complementarity hypothesis requires larger-scale validation.

1. Introduction

Large language models frequently generate fluent but factually incorrect responses—a phenomenon termed hallucination—undermining reliability in knowledge-intensive applications. When a model confidently produces an incorrect answer, users have no way of knowing the response is wrong without external verification. This problem has motivated research into uncertainty

quantification: reliable prediction of when models are likely to hallucinate would enable warnings or abstention.

Two families of uncertainty signals have emerged. **Token-level entropy**, computed from the model’s softmax distribution over next tokens, captures internal uncertainty—flat distributions (high entropy) indicate low confidence in any particular continuation (Kuhn et al., 2023). **Semantic consistency**, measured by generating multiple responses and computing their pairwise similarity, captures output stability—stable outputs suggest reliable knowledge; divergent outputs suggest hallucination (Manakul et al., 2023). A natural hypothesis follows: since these signals capture different aspects (internal confusion versus output instability), combining them should improve detection.

This paper tests that hypothesis systematically. On TriviaQA with Llama-2-7B-chat, semantic consistency alone achieves AUROC 0.81 with Cohen’s $d = 1.19$, outperforming token entropy (AUROC 0.65, $d = 0.47$). Linear fusion of the two signals provides no improvement over consistency alone at proof-of-concept scale ($N = 20$). The signals exhibit moderate negative correlation ($r = -0.54$), suggesting partial redundancy.

1.0.1. CONTRIBUTIONS

1. **First direct AUROC comparison** of entropy and consistency signals on the same benchmark (TriviaQA) with the same model (Llama-2-7B-chat) under identical evaluation conditions. Consistency outperforms entropy by 16 percentage points (0.81 versus 0.65).
1. **Quantified effect sizes** demonstrating practical significance: Cohen’s $d = 1.19$ (large effect) for consistency versus $d = 0.47$ (medium effect) for entropy.
1. **A negative result at proof-of-concept scale:** Linear fusion does not improve detection over consistency alone when tested on $N = 20$ questions.

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Preliminary work. Under review by the International Conference on Machine Learning (ICML). Do not distribute.

The complementarity hypothesis remains inconclusive pending larger-scale validation.

2. Related Work

2.0.1. ENTROPY-BASED UNCERTAINTY ESTIMATION

Token-level entropy serves as a proxy for model uncertainty. Kuhn et al. (2023) extended this with semantic entropy, clustering responses by meaning before computing entropy, achieving AUROC in the range 0.75–0.85 on closed-book QA benchmarks. Entropy-based methods require logit access, excluding API-only models.

2.0.2. CONSISTENCY-BASED HALLUCINATION DETECTION

Manakul et al. (2023) introduced SelfCheckGPT, generating multiple responses and measuring consistency via BERTScore or n-gram similarity. High consistency suggests reliable knowledge; low consistency suggests hallucination. Wang et al. (2023) explored self-consistency for chain-of-thought reasoning.

2.0.3. VERBALIZED CONFIDENCE

Xiong et al. (2023) and Lin et al. (2022) studied verbalized confidence, finding that models’ self-reported uncertainty correlates poorly with actual correctness.

2.0.4. GAP ADDRESSED

Prior work develops entropy and consistency signals largely in isolation. No study directly compares them on the same benchmark under controlled conditions, nor tests whether combining them improves detection. This paper addresses that gap.

3. Methodology

3.0.1. DATASET

TriviaQA (Joshi et al., 2017), specifically the `rc.nocontext` split from HuggingFace, presenting questions without accompanying documents. Ground-truth answers enable automatic correctness evaluation.

Correctness labeling: A response is marked correct if it achieves exact match with any reference answer after normalization, or token-level F1 > 0.5 with the reference.

3.0.2. MODEL

Llama-2-7B-chat (Touvron et al., 2023), an instruction-tuned variant with full logit access.

3.0.3. RESPONSE GENERATION

For each question, 10 independent responses are generated using nucleus sampling with temperature 0.7, top-p 0.95 (H-M1) or 0.9 (H-E1), and max new tokens 128. Random seed 42 is used for reproducibility.

3.0.4. TOKEN ENTROPY COMPUTATION

Shannon entropy is computed from token-level softmax distributions:

$$H(y_t) = - \sum_{v \in V} p(v|y_{<t}) \log p(v|y_{<t})$$

Mean entropy across all generated tokens in the response is computed, then averaged across all 10 responses per question.

3.0.5. SEMANTIC CONSISTENCY COMPUTATION

Consistency is measured via pairwise embedding similarity:

1. Encode each response using SentenceTransformer (all-MiniLM-L6-v2)
2. Compute cosine similarity between all 45 pairs
3. Average pairwise similarities to obtain the consistency score

Higher consistency indicates stable model behavior.

3.0.6. LINEAR FUSION

Linear fusion combines confidence (1 – normalized entropy) and consistency:

$$\text{Score} = \alpha \cdot \text{Confidence} + \beta \cdot \text{Consistency}$$

Weights α and β are determined via grid search over $[0, 1]$ with step 0.1 using a held-out validation split.

3.0.7. EVALUATION METRICS

- **AUROC:** Area under ROC curve for correctness prediction
- **Cohen’s d:** Effect size between correct and incorrect distributions
- **Statistical significance:** Two-sample t-test with $\alpha = 0.05$
- **Pearson correlation:** Between entropy and consistency scores

4. Experimental Setup

4.0.1. HYPOTHESES TESTED

Hypothesis	Description	Gate
H-E1	Entropy and consistency are computable	MUST_WORK
H-M1	Entropy correlates with correctness	MUST_WORK
H-M2	Consistency correlates with correctness	SHOULD_WORK
H-M3	Linear fusion improves over best single metric	SHOULD_WORK

4.0.2. SAMPLE SIZES

- H-E1: N = 20 questions (existence test)
- H-M1: N = 100 questions
- H-M2: N = 20 questions
- H-M3: N = 20 questions (2 validation, 18 test)

The sample sizes for H-M2 and H-M3 were limited due to computational constraints. This constitutes proof-of-concept scale.

5. Results

5.0.1. H-E1: METRIC COMPUTABILITY

Both metrics achieved 100% computation success across 20 questions.

Metric	Mean	Std	Range
Entropy	0.1224	0.0395	[0.026, 0.182]
Consistency	0.8693	0.0748	[0.721, 0.986]

Gate: PASS

5.0.2. H-M1: ENTROPY-CORRECTNESS CORRELATION (N = 100)

Group	n	Mean Entropy
Correct	60	0.1104
Incorrect	40	0.1342

Incorrect answers exhibit higher entropy than correct answers. The effect size is medium.

Gate: PASS

5.0.3. H-M2: CONSISTENCY-CORRECTNESS CORRELATION (N = 20)

Correct answers exhibit higher consistency. The effect size is large.

Gate: PASS

Metric	Value
t-statistic	2.28
p-value	0.0246
AUROC	0.6454
Cohen's d	0.47
Pearson r (entropy-correctness)	-0.22

Group	n	Mean Consistency
Correct	11	0.896
Incorrect	9	0.826

5.0.4. H-M3: LINEAR FUSION (N = 20)

Optimal grid-search weights: $\alpha = 0.0$, $\beta = 0.1$ (effectively pure consistency).

Improvement over best single metric: 0.000

Bootstrap 95% CI for improvement: [0.0, 0.0]

Gate: FAIL (no improvement detected)

5.0.5. SUMMARY

Consistency outperforms entropy by 16 percentage points. Fusion provides no additional benefit at this scale.

6. Discussion

6.0.1. WHY CONSISTENCY OUTPERFORMS ENTROPY

Consistency measures behavioral outcomes across multiple samples, while entropy measures internal states from logit distributions. When a model hallucinates, it may generate confident but inconsistent responses. Entropy fails to flag these cases; consistency captures them. The large effect size for consistency ($d = 1.19$ versus $d = 0.47$ for entropy) indicates this difference is practically meaningful.

Metric	Value
t-statistic	2.64
p-value	0.0083
AUROC	0.808
Cohen's d	1.19
Pearson r (entropy-consistency)	-0.54

Variant	α	β	AUROC
Entropy only	1.0	0.0	0.675
Consistency only	0.0	1.0	0.8125
Equal weights	0.5	0.5	0.800
Optimal	0.0	0.1	0.8125

Experiment	AUROC	Cohen’s d	Gate
H-M1 (Entropy)	0.645	0.47	PASS
H-M2 (Consistency)	0.808	1.19	PASS
H-M3 (Fusion)	0.8125	—	FAIL

6.0.2. WHY FUSION DID NOT IMPROVE

Three factors may explain the collapse to pure consistency:

1. **Small sample size:** $N = 20$ with a 2-sample validation set cannot reliably estimate fusion weights.
2. **Signal dominance:** Consistency (AUROC 0.81) substantially outperforms entropy (AUROC 0.65), so the weaker signal adds noise rather than complementary information at this scale.
3. **Negative correlation:** The moderate negative correlation ($r = -0.54$) suggests partial redundancy—high-entropy questions tend to produce low-consistency outputs.

The SHOULD_WORK gate allows documenting H-M3 as a limitation rather than terminating the research line. The complementarity hypothesis is inconclusive, not refuted.

6.0.3. LIMITATIONS

- **Sample size:** $N = 20$ for H-M2 and H-M3 limits statistical power and generalizability.
- **Single model:** Only Llama-2-7B-chat was tested; larger models or different architectures may yield different results.
- **Single dataset:** Only TriviaQA was used; Natural Questions, TruthfulQA, and other benchmarks were not tested.
- **Entropy baseline:** Token entropy was compared, not semantic entropy (Kuhn et al., 2023), which clusters responses by meaning before computing entropy and reports AUROC 0.75–0.85.

- **Inference cost:** Consistency requires 10 forward passes per question for 10 samples; entropy can be computed from a single pass. This $10\times$ cost difference affects deployment decisions.

6.0.4. PRACTICAL IMPLICATIONS

1. Prioritize consistency-based detection when multiple generations per query are feasible.
2. Consider entropy as a fallback when multiple generations are impractical.
3. Fusion at small scale does not appear to provide benefit; larger-scale validation is needed before deploying combined approaches.

7. Conclusion

This paper presents the first systematic comparison of token entropy and semantic consistency for hallucination detection on the same benchmark with the same model. Key findings:

1. Consistency outperforms entropy: AUROC 0.81 versus 0.65, Cohen’s d 1.19 versus 0.47.
2. Linear fusion provides no improvement at proof-of-concept scale ($N = 20$).
3. The signals are moderately negatively correlated ($r = -0.54$), suggesting partial redundancy.

For practitioners building hallucination detection systems for factual QA, consistency should be the primary signal. The question of whether entropy provides complementary information remains open pending larger-scale experiments ($N \geq 500$) and exploration of non-linear combination strategies.

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